he and Krishna Kumar were focused on acquiring valuable assets abroad wherever they became available. The duo was even prepared to enter tie-ups that would enhance Tata Tea's presence internationally. Tata Tea soon collaborated with Hitachi in a 51:49 partnership to export tea and spices, the 'first foray into the Japanese market by an Indian company'. During the year, with the 'objective of becoming the major player in the global tea market', Tata Tea also snapped up a 51 per cent stake of Watawala Plantations, a 'recently privatised Sri Lankan regional tea plantation management company', for $6 million. Revealing Ratan's vision, Krishna Kumar told the *Financial Times*, 'Our ultimate objective is to have a major brand abroad.'

As Ratan expanded the company, he also pursued, with equal vigour, its modernization. He oversaw a 'large and comprehensive four year physical upgradation programme to refurbish' and 'greatly strengthen the production base of the company'. The modernization programme 'cost approximately Rs 160 crores'. By 1996, Tata Tea had become India's largest plantation company and one of the largest tea-manufacturing companies in the world, with around fifty-three tea gardens and 57,000 employees.

The company grew at a rapid pace. It acquired the Borjan and Konikar estates in Assam and the Butaburi garden in West Bengal, enhancing its tea production capacity by an additional 62m kg a year.

By the following year, Tata Tea became the 'world's largest exporter of instant tea to Western countries with a 15 per cent share in the US market'. For FY 1996–97, the company reported a total revenue of Rs 689 crore and a PAT of Rs 59 crore, a 33 and 28 per cent increase, respectively, over the previous year. In the same year, Krishna Kumar was also appointed as the vice chairman of Tata Tea.

It was a practice for Ratan to address the stakeholders directly whenever possible especially when he intended to make large-scale changes in any of his companies. In keeping with this tradition, in the case of Tata Tea, in April 1997 he directly communicated with the tea workers in the remote hills of Munnar about the changes that he expected to bring about in the company and what he would expect as their contribution to it. He received a rousing reception. 'He endears himself to people,' says Adi Engineer. 'He will walk in, shake hands with all those who are present, have a smile for everyone, electrifying the atmosphere.'